

EAST AUSTRALIAN FORESTS

A damp corner of the drought continent

As moisture-laden winds from the Pacific Ocean rise over Australia's southeastern and eastern coast toward the Great Dividing Range, water vapor condenses into rain. This is especially true in the Australian Alps, where rainfall may exceed 90 in (2,300 mm) yearly, and in the Blue Mountains, near Sydney. Tasmania's hills commonly have winter snows, while 1,240 miles (2,000 km) north in southern Queensland, the climate is subtropical.

Eucalypt patchwork

Within this moist, warm mosaic are patches of temperate forest, dominated by more than 120 kinds of eucalypts, or gum trees. Upland eucalypts, especially the tall mountain ash gum, cloak rocky crags and steep gorges. More gum forests and acacia woods, including the golden wattle, grow on lower slopes, as well as ferns, banksias, and grevilleas. This ecoregion is home to some of Australia's most famous animals, including the Tasmanian devil, koala, duck-billed platypus, short-beaked echidna, laughing kookaburra, and Albert's lyrebird. However, human expansion has meant felling and conversion of forest to farmland, while introduced pests such as rabbits, foxes, and cats ravage the native wildlife.

More than **a fifth of Australia's eucalypts** grow here, but are threatened by **climate change**

